אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ וּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ

AVRAHAM AVINU AND MESIRAS NEFESH

The Akeidah and Devotion Beyond Personal Reward

Hebrew English Interlinear Sources

With Source Footnotes

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About This Collection

These fifteen sources trace mesiras nefesh from Avraham Avinu at Ur Kasdim to the Akeidah, and from those events to the inner avodah of surrendering one's own will and spiritual benefit for Hashem. The collection includes the sources in the shared discussion, the passage in Kedushas Shabbos, its Midrashic source, and three additional Chassidic parallels.

The distinctions in the sources matter. Kedushas Shabbos speaks of accepting even the possibility of punishment. Shekalim explicitly mentions forfeiting Olam Haba in its discussion of the furnace. Beis Yaakov explicitly applies surrender of Olam Haba to the Akeidah and to the spiritual future embodied in Yitzchak. Mei HaShiloach and Sfas Emes explain the broader meaning of this avodah.

The passages are selected excerpts, translated in full within their stated boundaries. Hebrew vowel points and expanded abbreviations are editorial. English translations are original to this collection. Numbered source notes accompany the Hebrew. Section titles and contextual notes are editorial.

A special Parshas Vayeira Dvar Torah opens the study, exploring the Akeidah through these sources and its meaning for daily avodah.

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The Hebrew passages are excerpts from the cited source works.

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Parshas Vayeira

The Deeper Meaning of the Akeidah

Mesiras Nefesh and Giving Up Everything

An editorial Dvar Torah based on the interlinear sources in this collection

Avraham Avinu approaches the Akeidah with far more than his own life at stake. Yitzchak is his beloved son, the child of the Divine promise, and the one through whom his avodah is meant to continue. Everything Avraham has built seems bound up with this child. Yet he is prepared to place even that future before Hashem.

Read together, Rav Tzadok HaKohen and the Beis Yaakov reveal several layers of this mesiras nefesh. Avraham gives up his claim to personal comfort and reward; he places the future of his avodah in Hashem's hands; and he yields the demand that he understand how Hashem's command and promise fit together. The Akeidah brings the deepest part of the self into the service of Hashem.

Something dearer than life

Avraham had already shown at Ur Kasdim that his love for Hashem could carry him through the prospect of death. Rav Tzadok therefore distinguishes the furnace from the Akeidah. A person may be prepared to die while knowing that his deepest hopes will survive him. At the Akeidah, Avraham was prepared to surrender what was dearer to him than his own continued life.

וְכֵן קֹדֶם מִקּוּדָּם בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ בְּנִסָּיוֹן הַכִּבְשָׁן — **He had already fulfilled with all your soul in the trial of the furnace.** וְאַחַר כָּךְ נִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵדָה נִקְרָא וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ — **Afterward, the trial of the Akeidah was called with all your might,** שֶׁמּוֹרֶה אַף דָּבָר שֶׁחָבִיב עָלָיו מְאֹד יוֹתֵר מִנַּפְשׁוֹ.[1] — **which includes even something exceedingly dear to him, more than his own life.**

The words bechol meodecha reach into everything that a person calls his own. In Avraham's case, that included Yitzchak and the future entrusted to him. His mesiras nefesh reached the place where a person feels that the entire meaning of his life is being asked of him.

Even the Olam Haba embodied in Yitzchak

The Beis Yaakov states this with extraordinary clarity. Yitzchak was the very essence of Avraham's Olam Haba. He was the beloved son through whom the covenant would continue. Avraham was prepared to give even this good to Hashem, without reserving a spiritual possession that must remain his own.

וּכְמוֹ שֶׁעָשָׂה בְּהַעֲקֵידָה שֶׁרָצָה לְהַקְרִיב בְּנוֹ יְחִידוֹ אֲשֶׁר אֲהֵבוֹ עוֹלָה כָּלִיל לְהַשֵּׁם, — **As he did at the Akeidah, when he desired to offer his only son, whom he loved, as a complete burnt offering to Hashem,** וְאַף שֶׁזֹּאת הִיא עִיקַּר עוֹלָם הַבָּא שֶׁלּוֹ, — **and although this was the very essence of his World to Come,** עִם כָּל זֶה רָצָה גַּם בְּזוֹ הַטּוֹבָה לַעֲבוֹד בְּפְעוּלַת הַשֵּׁם — **nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service,** וְאַף שֶׁלֹּא יִשָּׁאֵר לוֹ כְּלוּם.[2] — **even if nothing would remain for himself.**

This describes Avraham's readiness to surrender; it does not say that Hashem ultimately took away his Olam Haba. The depth of the avodah lies in what he was willing to place before Hashem. His service did not depend on an assurance that his own spiritual future would emerge in a form he could recognize.

A love beyond the calculation of reward

Kedushas Shabbos brings us to a still more searching point. The Satan challenges Avraham with the claim that he will ultimately be held guilty of shedding his son's blood. Rav Tzadok explains Avraham's response as a readiness to serve even against the hypothetical possibility of punishment. His intention is to bring Hashem nachas ruach.

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[1] **Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah, maamar 15, concluding passage; original Hebrew 15:3; reader 15:7**.

[2] **Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55; reader paragraphs 1, 2 and 4; Sefaria 55:1**.

וַאֲפִילּוּ יִהְיֶה אֱמֶת שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ אַחַר כָּךְ עַל זֶה. **— Even if it should be true that he will afterward be punished for this,** הוּא רוֹצֶה רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְלֹא לְקַבָּלַת שָׂכָר. **— he desires only to perform all his actions for the sake of Heaven, without seeking to receive reward.** וַאֲפִילּוּ יֵעָנֵשׁ עַל זֶה הוּא מִתְכַּוֵּין לַעֲשׂוֹת נַחַת רוּחַ לְפָנָיו[3] **— Even if he should be punished for it, his intention is to bring Him nachas ruach,**

A person can leave behind many material desires while still holding tightly to the spiritual benefit he expects from his avodah. These sources ask him to examine that attachment as well. Avraham's desire is that Hashem's will be fulfilled. Even the anticipated reward of the servant is placed in the hands of the One he serves.

Giving up his own account of the right outcome

Rav Tzadok explains in Toldos and Pesach that Avraham's ahavah could have supplied a powerful argument for preserving Yitzchak. Through Yitzchak, Hashem's Divinity would become known in the world. Avraham could have understood that future as the very purpose of his life's work. His yirah made him examine whether even this spiritual argument was being influenced by his love for his son.

אַךְ מִיִּרְאָתוֹ הַמּוּפְלָגֶת יָרֵא לַעֲבוֹר פִּי הַשֵּׁם **— But because of his extraordinary awe, he feared to transgress Hashem's word,** שֶׁחֲשַׁד עַצְמוֹ אֶת בַּדָּבָר לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ מַה בַּדָּבָר הוּא נוֹגֵעַ פֶּן.[4] **— suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter.**

Here mesiras nefesh reaches the way a person understands his own avodah. Avraham submits even his cherished account of how Hashem's honor should be revealed. His yirah gives his ahavah its full purity: the love itself must answer to Hashem's will.

Emunah when the reconciliation is hidden

The Mei HaShiloach preserves a vital part of the picture. Avraham continued to believe Hashem's earlier promises while proceeding with the Akeidah. He did not need to possess the explanation of how those promises would be fulfilled in order to remain faithful to them.

כִּי אַף שֶׁאָמַר לוֹ כֹּה יִהְיֶה זַרְעֶךָ, **— For although He had told him: So shall your offspring be,** וְנֶאֱמַר לוֹ אֶת בְּיִצְחָק תִּי אַקִּים אֶת בְּרִיתִי, **— and he had been told: I shall establish My covenant with Yitzchak,** וְעַכְשָׁיו כְּשֶׁנֶּאֱמַר לוֹ הַעֲלֵהוּ לְעוֹלָה **— and now he was told: Bring him up as a burnt offering,** עִם כָּל זֶה הֶאֱמִין בַּדְּבָרִים הָרִאשׁוֹנִים כְּמוֹ מִקֹּדֶם וְלֹא נָפְלוּ אֶצְלוֹ, **— nevertheless he believed in the earlier statements just as before, and they did not lose their standing for him.** וְזֹאת הָאֱמוּנָה אֵין בְּשֵׂכֶל הָאָדָם לְהַשִּׂיג,[5] **— This faith is beyond the grasp of human understanding.**

Avraham's emunah holds the promise and the command together while their reconciliation remains hidden from him. He entrusts the future to Hashem. Giving up everything includes yielding the demand that the whole picture become clear to me before I can serve with a complete heart.

The Akeidah within daily avodah

The Sfas Emes brings this avodah into the meaning of the word nefesh itself. Nefesh means will. The inner direction of mesiras nefesh is that a person's will becomes devoted to the ratzon of the Borei.

לִהְיוֹת כָּל רְצוֹנוֹ תָּמִיד רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא וְאֵין לוֹ דָּבָר אַחֵר בָּעוֹלָם **— that his entire will should always be only to fulfill the Creator's will, with nothing else in his world.** וְזֶה מִקְרֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ כִּי נֶפֶשׁ הוּא רָצוֹן **— This is called mesiras nefesh, for nefesh means will,** וְעַל יְדֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בְּפוֹעַל זוֹכִין לְזֶה הָרָצוֹן.[6] **— and through actual mesiras nefesh one merits this will.**

This gives us a way to approach the Akeidah in ordinary life. A mitzvah may ask for time that I wanted to keep, honesty that carries a financial cost, tzedakah without recognition, or patience when I want to insist on

[3] **Pri Tzaddik, Sefer Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, paragraph 9**.

[4] **Pri Tzaddik, Toldos, maamar 1, paragraph 4**.

[5] **Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Vayeira 8, beginning VehaElokim nissah**.

[6] **Sfas Emes, Balak, 5656, second paragraph; Sefaria Numbers, Balak 21:2**.

my own way. In each case, something within the self can be offered to Hashem. The Beis Yaakov explicitly connects a mitzvah performed without an ulterior motive to Akeidas Yitzchak.

וְאִם עוֹשֶׂה מִצְוַת הַשֵּׁם בְּלִי שׁוּם פְּנִיָּה רַק לִרְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, **— If he performs Hashem's mitzvah without any ulterior motive, solely for Hashem's will,** אָז נוֹגֵעַ הַפְּעוּלָה מַעְלָה מַעְלָה, **— then the act reaches higher and higher,** שֶׁתִּהְיֶה לָהּ אֶחָיזָה בַּעֲקֵידַת יִצְחָק,[7] **— so that it has a connection to Akeidas Yitzchak.**

To receive everything from Hashem anew

The conclusion of the Akeidah completes this understanding. Avraham must now hear Hashem's command to stop. The same surrender of will that brought him up the mountain requires him to receive Yitzchak back as Hashem directs.

אַל תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנַּעַר וְאַל תַּעַשׂ לוֹ מְאוּמָה[8] **— Do not stretch out your hand against the lad, and do nothing to him.**

The avodah is complete devotion to the ratzon Hashem, through the giving and through the receiving. Yitzchak remains alive, and Avraham continues to serve with the gift that has been entrusted to him.

For us, the deeper meaning of giving up everything is to bring every part of life into that devotion: our comforts, our plans, our need for recognition, our hopes for spiritual achievement, and our insistence on understanding the outcome. We ask that all of them find their proper place in the service of Hashem. That is the Akeidah we carry into the avodah of this week.

[7] **Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55; reader paragraphs 1, 2 and 4; Sefaria 55:1**.

[8] **Bereishis 22:12**.

Interlinear Source Collection

1 Bereishis Rabbah

The challenge before the Akeidah

Samael challenges Avraham with the claim that he will ultimately be held guilty of shedding his son's blood. This is the Midrash explained in the following passage of Kedushas Shabbos.

אָמַר לוֹ לְמָחָר אוֹמֵר לְךָ שׁוֹפֵךְ דָּם אַתָּה חַיָּב שֶׁשָּׁפַכְתָּ דָּמוֹ שֶׁל בְּנֶךָ, **— He said to him: Tomorrow He will say to you, You are a shedder of blood; you are liable for having shed your son's blood.** אָמַר לוֹ, עַל מְנָת כֵּן.[9] **— Avraham answered him: Even on that condition.**

2 Pri Tzaddik Kedushas Shabbos

Serving even without reward

Rav Tzadok explains Avraham's response to the Satan. The statement concerns the Akeidah and explicitly accepts the hypothetical possibility of punishment; the words Olam Haba do not occur in this selected statement.

וְהוּא הֵשִׁיב עַל מְנָת כֵּן, **— And he answered: Even on that condition,** דְּמִכָּל מָקוֹם כַּוָּנָתוֹ לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְעוֹשֶׂה עֲבֵירָה לִשְׁמָהּ.[10] **— for in any event his intention is for the sake of Heaven, and he acts in the manner of a transgression undertaken for Heaven's sake.** וַאֲפִילּוּ יִהְיֶה אֱמֶת שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ אַחַר כָּךְ עַל זֶה. **— Even if it should be true that he will afterward be punished for this,** הוּא רוֹצֶה רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְלֹא לְקַבָּלַת שָׂכָר. **— he desires only to perform all his actions for the sake of Heaven, without seeking to receive reward.** וַאֲפִילּוּ יֵעָנֵשׁ עַל זֶה הוּא מִתְכַּוֵּין לַעֲשׂוֹת נַחַת רוּחַ לְפָנָיו **— Even if he should be punished for it, his intention is to bring Him nachas ruach,** מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן בְּהֵיפֶךְ כַּוָּנָתוֹ לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ.[11] **— whereas, in taking the opposite course, his intention would be directed toward his love for his son.**

3 Pri Tzaddik Shekalim

Surrendering both worlds and then his understanding

The first excerpt refers to the fiery furnace. Later in the same maamar, Rav Tzadok explains the Akeidah through Avraham's yirah and his readiness to obey beyond his understanding.

The furnace

וְרַק מִפְּנֵי שֶׁבָּעֲרָה בּוֹ אַהֲבַת הַשֵּׁם מָסַר נַפְשׁוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ גַּם כֵּן **— It was only because love of Hashem burned within him that he surrendered his life and his soul as well,** וְאַף שֶׁיִּפְסִיד חַס וְשָׁלוֹם חֶלְקוֹ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא מַה בְּכָךְ **— and even if, Heaven forbid, he should lose his portion in the World to Come, what of it?** כֵּיוָן שֶׁרָצוֹנוֹ שֶׁיִּתְקַדֵּשׁ שֵׁם שָׁמַיִם עַל יָדוֹ וְיִתְפָּרְסֵם אֱלֹהוּתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שְׁמוֹ. **— For his desire was that the Name of Heaven be sanctified through him, and that His Divinity, blessed be His Name, become known.**

The Akeidah

אַף אָז הִשְׁתַּמֵּשׁ בְּמִדַּת הַיִּרְאָה בְּהַפְלָגָה **— But then he exercised the attribute of awe to an extraordinary degree,** וְנִתְיָרֵא לַעֲבוֹר עַל רְצוֹנוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ **— and feared to transgress His blessed will,** וְחָשַׁד אֶת עַצְמוֹ פֶּן הוּא נוֹגֵעַ מַה בַּדָּבָר לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ **— suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter.** וְאָז נִתְכַּלֵּל בְּאֶשָּׁא מִדַּת יִצְחָק **— He was then encompassed within the fire, the attribute of Yitzchak.**

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[9] **Bereishis Rabbah 56:4**.

[10] **Nazir 23b**. "Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak said: A transgression for Heaven's sake is greater than a mitzvah performed without that intention. But did Rav Yehudah not say in the name of Rav: A person should always engage in Torah and mitzvos even without the proper intention, for from doing them without that intention he will come to do them with it? Rather, say: It is like a mitzvah performed without the proper intention. For it is written: Blessed above women shall Yael, the wife of Chever the Kenite, be; above women in the tent shall she be blessed. Who are the women in the tent? Sarah, Rivkah, Rochel and Leah."

[11] **Pri Tzaddik, Sefer Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, paragraph 9**.

וְזֶה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בְּנִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵידָה עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה וְגוֹמֵר[12] **— This is what is stated in the trial of the Akeidah: Now I know that you fear God, and so forth** וְנִתְבָּאֵר תּוֹלְדוֹת מַאֲמָר א׳ דִּבּוּר הַמַּתְחִיל וּמַסִּיק **— as explained in Toldos, maamar 1, in the passage beginning Umasik.** וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁאָמַר מַה לִּי אִם אֵינִי מֵבִין כֵּיוָן שֶׁכָּךְ צִוּוּיתִי אֲנִי מְחוּיָב לִשְׁמוֹעַ.[13] **— That is, he said: What does it matter that I do not understand? Since I have been commanded in this way, I am obligated to obey.**

4 Pri Tzaddik Toldos

Examining even a spiritual justification

Rav Tzadok first explains that Avraham's ahavah could have supplied an argument for preserving Yitzchak so that Hashem's Divinity would continue to be proclaimed through him. The following sentence explains why Avraham would not rely on that argument.

אַף מִיִּרְאָתוֹ הַמּוּפְלָגֶת יָרֵא לַעֲבוֹר פִּי הַשֵּׁם **— But because of his extraordinary awe, he feared to transgress Hashem's word,** שֶׁחָשַׁשׁ אֶת עַצְמוֹ פֶּן הוּא נוֹגֵעַ מַה בַּדָּבָר לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ.[14] **— suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter.**

5 Pri Tzaddik Pesach

Love completed through awe

Immediately before this excerpt, Rav Tzadok explicitly describes Avraham's willingness at the furnace to surrender his life and his share in Olam Haba. He then tests what that same ahavah might have suggested at the Akeidah, and shows its completion through yirah.

וְכֵן עַל פִּי מִדַּת אַהֲבָה זוֹ הָיָה צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹר עַל מִצְוַת עֲקֵידַת יִצְחָק. **— Likewise, according to this attribute of love, he would have had reason to transgress the command of Akeidas Yitzchak,** כֵּיוָן שֶׁיָּדַע כִּי בְיִצְחָק יִקָּרֵא לְךָ וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁעַל יָדוֹ יִתְפָּרְסֵם אֱלֹקִיתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ[15] **— since he knew: Through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours, — meaning that through him His blessed Divinity would become known.** וְלֹא רָצָה שֶׁאֱלִיעֶזֶר יִהְיֶה הַמְפַרְסֵם אֱלֹקִיתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ **— He did not want Eliezer to be the one who would proclaim His blessed Divinity,** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁאָמַר וּבֶן מֶשֶׁק בֵּיתִי הוּא דַּמֶּשֶׂק אֱלִיעֶזֶר,[16] **— as he said: And the steward of my household is Eliezer of Damascus.** אַף מִפְּנֵי יִרְאָתוֹ הָעֲצוּמָה לַעֲבוֹר עַל מִצְוַת הַשֵּׁם **— But because of his tremendous fear of transgressing Hashem's command,** שָׁמָא יֵשׁ לוֹ נְגִיעָה לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ **— lest his love for his son be influencing him,** עַל פִּי מִדַּת הַיִּרְאָה הַזּוֹ עָקַד אֶת יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ **— he bound his son Yitzchak in accordance with this attribute of awe.** וְזֶה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יְרֵא אֱלֹקִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ וְגוֹמֵר. **— This is what is stated: For now I know that you fear God, and you have not withheld, and so forth.** וְאָז נִשְׁלַם בְּמִדַּת הָאַהֲבָה כְּשֶׁבָּא עַל יְדֵי יִרְאָה,[17] **— His attribute of love was then brought to completion when it came through awe.**

6 Pri Tzaddik Chanukah

The Akeidah beyond surrendering his own life

This passage explicitly distinguishes the furnace from the Akeidah. It describes surrendering what is more precious than one's own life, without explicitly using the words Olam Haba.

וְכֵן קַיֵּם מִקּוֹדֶם בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ בְּנִסָּיוֹן הַכִּבְשָׁן **— He had already fulfilled with all your soul in the trial of the furnace.** וְאַחַר כָּךְ נִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵדָה נִקְרָא וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ[18] **— Afterward, the trial of the Akeidah was called with all**

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[12] **Bereishis 22:12**. “He said: Do not stretch out your hand against the lad, and do nothing to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only one, from Me.”

[13] **Pri Tzaddik, Parshas Shekalim, maamar 7, paragraph 1**.

[14] **Pri Tzaddik, Toldos, maamar 1, paragraph 4**.

[15] **Bereishis 21:12**. “God said to Avraham: Do not let it be distressing in your eyes concerning the lad and concerning your maidservant. Whatever Sarah tells you, listen to her voice, for through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours.”

[16] **Bereishis 15:2**. “Avram said: My Lord, Hashem, what will You give me, since I go childless, and the steward of my household is Eliezer of Damascus?”

[17] **Pri Tzaddik, Pesach, maamar 52, paragraph 1**.

[18] **Devarim 6:5**. “You shall love Hashem your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might.”

your might, שֶׁמּוֹרֶה אַף דָּבָר שֶׁחָבִיב עָלָיו מְאֹד יוֹתֵר מִנַּפְשׁוֹ. **— which includes even something exceedingly dear to him, more than his own life.** וּמִכָּל מָקוֹם שִׁבְחוֹ הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ בִּבְחִינַת יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים **— Nevertheless, Hashem praised him as one who fears God,** מִפְּנֵי שֶׁאָז עָשָׂה מִצְוַת הָאַהֲבָה בְּכֹחַ וּגְבוּרָה **— because then he fulfilled the mitzvah of love with strength and might,** שֶׁבָּעֵר בּוֹ הָאַהֲבָה בְּשַׁלְהֶבֶת יָהּ.[19] **— as love burned within him with a flame of God.**

7 Tzidkas HaTzaddik

Surrendering even the neshamah

This opening statement extends mesiras nefesh beyond its ordinary literal sense. Rav Tzadok then cites the Zohar's inclusion of nefesh, ruach and neshamah, and develops examples involving love of Hashem, Torah and Israel. The selected sentence itself does not explicitly mention forfeiting Olam Haba.

מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בִּשְׁבִיל אַהֲבַת הַשֵּׁם **— Mesiras nefesh out of love for Hashem** אֵינוֹ הַנֶּפֶשׁ לְבַד כִּפְשׁוּטָיהּ **— does not mean one's life alone in the literal sense,** אֶלָּא גַּם הַנְּשָׁמָה.[20] **— but also the neshamah.**

8 Mei HaShiloach Vaeschanan

Surrendering Olam Haba and the qualification

The Izhbitzer explains why the first paragraph of Shema says with all your might, while the second does not. His qualification concerning a person's clarified spiritual portion is retained in the excerpt.

וּבְפָרָשַׁת וְהָיָה אִם שָׁמוֹעַ לֹא נֶאֱמַר וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶיכֶם, **— In the paragraph Vehayah im shamoa, it does not say with all your might,** כִּי מְאֹדְךָ הַיְינוּ מְאֹד מְאֹד לְמָסוֹר אֶת נַפְשׁוֹ עַל קְדֻשַּׁת שְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ, **— for meodecha means an exceedingly great surrender of one's soul for the sanctification of His blessed Name,** הַיְינוּ לְמָסוֹר נַפְשׁוֹ אַף בְּחַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא; **— meaning to surrender oneself even with respect to life in the World to Come.** וְזֶהוּ רַק קוֹדֶם שֶׁיִּתְבָּרֵר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ הַשַּׁיָּךְ לוֹ בְּשָׁרְשׁוֹ, **— This applies only before the portion belonging to a person at his root has become clear to him,** כִּי לְכָל נֶפֶשׁ שַׁיָּךְ מִצְוָה מְיוּחֶדֶת **— for to every soul there belongs a particular mitzvah** שֶׁעַל יָדָהּ יַגִּיעַ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא כְּפִי הַמִּצְוָה וּכְפִי אֲשֶׁר יְקַיְּמֶהָ, **— through which that soul will attain the World to Come, according to the mitzvah and the manner in which he fulfills it,** וְזֶה עִיקַּר לְכָל נֶפֶשׁ; **— and this is fundamental for each soul.** וְקוֹדֶם שֶׁנִּתְבָּרֵר לְאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹד אֶת הַשֵּׁם בְּזֶה הָאוֹפֶן **— Before his portion has become clear to him, a person must serve Hashem in this manner:** שֶׁלֹּא יִמָּצֵא אֶצְלוֹ דָּבָר שֶׁלֹּא יוּכַל לְמָסְרָהּ עַל קִדּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם; **— that there be nothing in his possession which he would be unable to surrender for Kiddush Hashem.** אַךְ אַחַר שֶׁיְּבוֹרַר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ **— But after a person's portion has been clarified,** לֹא יַחְפֹּץ הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ מִן הָאָדָם שֶׁיַּעֲבוֹד אוֹתוֹ בְּזֶה הָאוֹפֶן, **— Hashem does not desire that he serve Him in this manner,** כִּי לֹא יִרְצֶה הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לִיקַּח מִן הָאָדָם מַה שֶּׁסִּיֵּג;[21] **— for Hashem does not wish to take from a person what he has acquired.**

9 Mei HaShiloach Emor

Readiness without benefit in either world

The Izhbitzer interprets the aravah, which has neither taste nor fragrance, as a necessary dimension of spiritual completeness. His concluding statement that Hashem will restore what was lost is included.

עַרְבֵי נַחַל הוּא עֹנֶג רַע, כִּי אֵין בָּהּ לֹא טַעַם וְלֹא רֵיחַ; **— The willows of the brook correspond to the depth of evil, for the willow has neither taste nor fragrance.** וְהַעְנְיָן בָּזֶה כִּדְאִיתָא בַּגְּמָרָא: **— The meaning is as stated in the Gemara:** כָּל הַמּוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ לָמוּת עַל דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה אֵין אוֹמְרִים דָּבָר הֲלָכָה מִשְׁמוֹ, בָּבָא קַמָּא דַּף ס״א.[22] **— Whoever gives himself over to die for words of Torah, a halachic teaching is not stated in his name.**

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[19] **Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah, maamar 15, concluding passage; original Hebrew 15:3; reader 15:7**.

[20] **Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201, opening sentence**.

[21] **Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Vaeschanan 11, on Devarim 6:5**.

[22] **Bava Kamma 61a**. “He did not state the teachings in their names. He said: This is the tradition I have received from the court of Shmuel of Ramah: Whoever gives himself over to die for words of Torah, a halachic teaching is not stated in his name.”

Bava Kamma 61a. וְנִרְאֶה שֶׁמִּזֶּה הַמַּעֲשֶׂה לֹא יַגִּיעַ לְהָאָדָם שׁוּם הֲנָאָה לֹא בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְלֹא בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא; — **It appears that from this act no benefit will reach the person, either in this world or in the World to Come.** כִּי אֲגוּדָּה אַף בְּהַאֲגוּדָּה מֵהַצּוֹרֶךְ גַּם עֲרָבָה לְהִמָּצֵא, — **Yet the willow, too, must be present in the bundle,** רוֹמֵז עַל שְׁלֵימוּת הָאָדָם, וּבִשְׁלֵימוּת הָאָדָם צָרִיךְ לְהִמָּצֵא גַּם הַכֹּחַ הַזֶּה — **for the bundle alludes to the completeness of the person.** שֶׁיּוּכַל לִמְסוֹר נַפְשׁוֹ לְמוּת אַף שֶׁלֹּא יִגִּיעַ לוֹ הֲנָאָה אַף לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא; — **For the person's completeness, this capacity must also be present: that he be able to surrender his life unto death even if no benefit will reach him, even in the World to Come.** וּבְאִם יִמָּצֵא בָּאָדָם זֶה הַכֹּחַ אָז יַשִּׂיג גַּם שְׁאָר הָעוֹמְקִים בִּשְׁלֵימוּת, — **If this capacity is present in a person, he will then attain the other depths in their completeness as well.** וְעַל יְדֵי זֶה יִקָּרֵא עוֹמֶק, לְפִי שֶׁגַּם בְּהָרַע יִמָּצֵא טוֹב — **Through this it is called a depth, because good will be found even within the evil,** וְהִיא שֶׁלָּעָתִיד יַחֲזוֹר הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לְכָל מִי שֶׁהִפְסִיד בְּמָסִירוּת נַפְשׁוֹ עַל דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה.[23] — **namely, that in the future Hashem will restore to everyone what he lost through surrendering his life for words of Torah.**

10 Beis Yaakov Vayeira

Yitzchak as the Olam Haba of Avraham

This is the most explicit direct connection between the Akeidah and giving up Olam Haba. Beis Yaakov then extends the principle to an ordinary mitzvah performed entirely for Hashem.

Surrender reaching beyond what is known

וְהַטַּעַם בָּזֶה, כִּי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם — **The meaning is that Avraham Avinu, peace be upon him,** הִנִּיחַ וְעָזַב כָּל חֶמְדַּת עוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְאַף חַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא — **set aside and relinquished everything desirable in this world, and even the life of the World to Come,** בִּכְדֵי לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לְאֵתַר דְּלָא אִתְיְדַע, — **in order to fulfill Hashem's will, reaching the realm that is not known.** וּפְעוּלָה כָּזוֹ הִגִּיעָה לְרוּם הַמַּעֲלוֹת עַד לְעַתִּיקָא קַדִּישָׁא. — **Such an act reached the loftiest heights, as far as Atika Kadisha.**

Even if nothing would remain for himself

וְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָבַד לְהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ אַף בְּחַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא גַּם כֵּן, — **Avraham Avinu served Hashem with even the life of the World to Come as well,** וְכַעִנְיָן דְּאִיתָא תַּנְחוּמָא לֶךְ ג׳ — **in keeping with what is stated in Tanchuma, Lech Lecha 3:** נִסָּיוֹן הָרִאשׁוֹן כְּנִסָּיוֹן הָאַחֲרוֹן. — **The first trial was like the last trial.** נִסָּיוֹן הָאַחֲרוֹן בְּלֶךְ לְךָ וְנִסָּיוֹן הָרִאשׁוֹן בְּלֶךְ לְךָ,[24] — **The last trial was introduced with lech lecha, and the first trial was introduced with lech lecha.** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁעָשָׂה בְּהָעֲקֵידָה שֶׁרָצָה לְהַקְרִיב בְּנוֹ יְחִידוֹ אֲשֶׁר אָהֲבוֹ עוֹלָה כָּלִיל לְהַשֵּׁם, — **As he did at the Akeidah, when he desired to offer his only son, whom he loved, as a complete burnt offering to Hashem,** וְאַף שֶׁזֹּאת הִיא עִיקַּר עוֹלָם הַבָּא, — **and although this was the very essence of his World to Come,** עִם כָּל זֶה רָצָה גַּם בָּזוֹ הַטּוֹבָה לַעֲבוֹד בִּפְעוּלַת הַשֵּׁם — **nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service,** וְאַף שֶׁלֹּא יִשָּׁאֵר לוֹ כְּלוּם. — **even if nothing would remain for himself.** אַף כִּי אִיתָא רַבָּה בְּרֵאשִׁית מ״ד שֶׁהִבְטִיחַ לוֹ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שְׂכָרְךָ מְתוּקָן לָעָתִיד לָבֹא, — **Although it is stated in Bereishis Rabbah, Lech Lecha 44, that the Holy One, blessed be He, promised him, Your reward is prepared for the future,** אֵכֶן אֵין נִרְאֶה זֹאת לָעַיִן וְלֹא נוֹדַע לָאָדָם. — **this is nevertheless not visible to the eye and is not known to the person.**

Its expression in an ordinary mitzvah

וְאִם עוֹשֶׂה מִצְוַת הַשֵּׁם בְּלִי שׁוּם פְּנִיָּה רַק לִרְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, — **If he performs Hashem's mitzvah without any ulterior motive, solely for Hashem's will,** אָז נוֹגֵעַ הַפְּעוּלָה מַעְלָה מַעְלָה, — **then the act reaches higher and higher,** שֶׁהֲיָה לָהּ אֲחִיזָה בַּעֲקֵידַת יִצְחָק,[25] — **so that it has a connection to Akeidas Yitzchak.**

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[23] **Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Emor 9, beginning Chag haSukkos**.

[24] **Midrash Tanchuma, Lech Lecha 3:3**. "Rabbi Levi says: The first trial was like the last trial. The first trial was with Go forth from your land. The last trial was with Go forth to the land of Moriah."

[25] **Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55; reader paragraphs 1, 2 and 4; Sefaria 55:1**.

11 Beis Yaakov Toldos

Even spiritual reward can be self interest

Beis Yaakov states this spiritual ideal while explaining what Esav sought to convey through his question about tithing salt. The surrounding argument describes Esav's deceptive presentation to Yitzchak; it does not establish that Esav truly attained this avodah.

כִּי יֵשׁ גַּם עֲבוֹדָה גְּדוֹלָה מִזּוּ שֶׁהָאָדָם מוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ בְּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא בְּשָׁבִיל כְּבוֹד שָׁמַיִם — **For there is also a greater form of service than this: that a person surrenders himself through mesiras nefesh in this world and in the World to Come for the honor of Heaven.** כִּי גַּם כַּוָּנָה לְשָׁכָר בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא הוּא גַּם כֵּן לְנַרְמִיהּ[26] — **For even an intention directed toward the reward of the World to Come is also for oneself.**

12 Mei HaShiloach Vayeira

Faith beyond understanding

This passage adds a distinct dimension: Avraham retained his faith in Hashem's earlier promises even while proceeding with the Akeidah. It does not explicitly state that he forfeited Olam Haba.

וְהָאֱלֹקִים נִסָּה אֶת אַבְרָהָם. — **And God tested Avraham.** עִנְיַן נִסָּיוֹן שֶׁל הָעֲקֵדָה הָיָה גָּדֵל הָאֱמוּנָה שֶׁהָיָה לְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ בְּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, — **The matter tested at the Akeidah was the greatness of Avraham Avinu's faith in Hashem.** כִּי אַף שֶׁאָמַר לוֹ כֹּה יִהְיֶה זַרְעֶךָ,[27] — **For although He had told him: So shall your offspring be,** וְנֶאֱמַר לוֹ אֶת בְּרִיתִי אָקִים אֶת יִצְחָק,[28] — **and he had been told: I shall establish My covenant with Yitzchak,** וְעַכְשָׁיו כְּשֶׁנֶּאֱמַר לוֹ הַעֲלֵהוּ לְעוֹלָה עִם כָּל זֶה הֶאֱמִין בַּדְּבָרִים הָרִאשׁוֹנִים כְּמוֹ מִקֹּדֶם וְלֹא נָפְלוּ אֶצְלוֹ, — **nevertheless he believed in the earlier statements just as before, and they did not lose their standing for him.** וְזֹאת הָאֱמוּנָה אֵין בְּשֵׂכֶל הָאָדָם לְהַשִּׂיג,[29] — **This faith is beyond the grasp of human understanding.**

13 Kedushas Levi

Rochel surrendering her portion in both worlds

This additional Chassidic parallel explicitly states the general principle and illustrates it through Rochel giving Leah the identifying signs, despite the future she believed she might lose.

הַכְּלָל הוּא שֶׁאָדָם צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹד אֶת הַבּוֹרֵא בָּרוּךְ הוּא לֹא בְּשָׁבִיל שׂוּם קַבָּלַת שָׂכָר כְּלָל — **The principle is that a person must serve the Creator, blessed be He, without seeking any reward at all,** וְיִמְסוֹר עַצְמוֹ הֵן חֶלְקוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְהֵן חֶלְקוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּכְדֵי שֶׁיֵּעָשֶׂה רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא — **and surrender himself, both his portion in this world and his portion in the World to Come, in order to fulfill the Creator's will.** כְּמוֹ שֶׁמָּצִינוּ בְּרָחֵל שֶׁעָשְׂתָה הַמִּצְוָה לְמָסוֹר הַסִּימָנִים לְלֵאָה — **As we find with Rochel, who performed the mitzvah of handing over the identifying signs to Leah,** אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁעַל יְדֵי זֶה שׁוּב לֹא יִשָּׂא יַעֲקֹב וְתַעֲלֶה אֶל גּוֹרָלוֹ שֶׁל עֵשָׂו כַּנִּזְכָּר לְעֵיל — **even though, through this, Yaakov would no longer marry her and she would fall to Esav's lot, as stated above.** וְנִמְצָא חַס וְשָׁלוֹם תֹּאבַד חֶלְקָהּ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא כְּשֶׁיִּשָּׂא אוֹתָהּ עֵשָׂו חַס וְשָׁלוֹם — **It would follow, Heaven forbid, that she would lose her portion in the World to Come if Esav were to marry her, Heaven forbid.** אַף עַל פִּי כֵן מָסְרָה הַסִּימָנִים — **Nevertheless, she handed over the signs,** וּמָסְרָה עַצְמָהּ הֵן חֶלְקָהּ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה הֵן בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא — **and surrendered herself, both her portion in this world and in the World to Come,** בִּכְדֵי שֶׁיֵּעָשֶׂה רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא.[31] — **in order that the Creator's will be fulfilled.**

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[26] **Beis Yaakov on Torah, Toldos, ois 24, paragraph 1**.

[27] **Bereishis 15:5**. "He brought him outside and said: Look now toward the heavens and count the stars, if you are able to count them. And He said to him: So shall your offspring be."

[28] **Bereishis 17:21**. "But My covenant I shall establish with Yitzchak, whom Sarah shall bear to you at this appointed time next year."

[29] **Bereishis 22:2**. "He said: Take now your son, your only one, whom you love, Yitzchak, and go forth to the land of Moriah; and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains that I shall tell you."

[30] **Mei HaShiloach, Part I, Vayeira 8, beginning VehaElokim nissah**.

[31] **Kedushas Levi, Bereishis, Vayeitzei 26, beginning Uvazeh yevuar**.

14 Agra DeKalla

Avraham at Ur Kasdim

The Bnei Yissaschar develops this within his explanation of Yosef's reasoning about Avraham's status. The excerpt concerns the furnace, and expressly speaks of Avraham accepting even the prospect of punishment in Olam Haba.

וְיוֹסֵף הָיָה סוֹבֵר דְּשָׁאנֵי אַבְרָהָם דַּהֲרֵי מָסַר אֶת עַצְמוֹ עַל קִידּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם, — **Yosef held that Avraham was different, for he had surrendered himself for Kiddush Hashem,** וְהוּא שֶׁלֹּא כְתוֹרָה לְבָן נֹחַ דְּאֵינוֹ מְצוּוֶּה עַל קִידּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם, — **which was not in accordance with the law of a descendant of Noach, who is not commanded in Kiddush Hashem,** וְאִדְּרַבָּא מִתְחַיֵּב בְּאַךְ אֶת דִּמְכֶם לְנַפְשׁוֹתֵיכֶם וְכוּ׳ בְּרֵאשִׁית ט׳ ה׳,[32] — **and, on the contrary, incurs liability under But your blood, of your lives, and so forth, Bereishis 9:5.** אַךְ אַבְרָהָם בַּעֲבוּר קִדּוּשַׁת שְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ מָסַר אֶת עַצְמוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא, — **Yet Avraham, for the sanctification of His blessed Name, surrendered himself in this world and in the World to Come,** כִּי הָיָה חוֹשֵׁב שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא עַל מְסִירוּת נַפְשׁוֹ, — **for he thought that he would be punished in the World to Come for surrendering his life.** וְאַף עַל פִּי כֵן הִשְׁלִיךְ אֶת נַפְשׁוֹ מִנֶּגֶד עֲבוּר אַהֲבָתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שְׁמוֹ כַּאֲשֶׁר כָּתַבְנוּ בִּמְקוֹמוֹ, — **Nevertheless, he cast his life aside out of love for Him, blessed be His Name, as we explained in its place.** וְאִם כֵּן דִּין הוּא שֶׁיֵּצֵא מִכְּלַל בֶּן נֹחַ לְגַמְרֵי, מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן הַבָּנִים, וְהָבֵן.[33] — **If so, it is fitting that he should leave the status of a descendant of Noach entirely, unlike the children; understand this.**

15 Sfas Emes

Mesiras nefesh and the surrender of personal will

This additional parallel explains the meaning of nefesh as will, and connects Avraham's mesiras nefesh to service without expectation of reward. It speaks of unconditioned love rather than explicitly forfeiting Olam Haba.

Nefesh means will

כִּי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הָיָה הָרִאשׁוֹן שֶׁמָּסַר נַפְשׁוֹ לִשְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ — **For Avraham Avinu, peace be upon him, was the first to surrender his life for His blessed Name.** וּבָאֱמֶת בִּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ זוֹכִין אֶל זֶה הַזְּרִיזוּת — **Through mesiras nefesh, one truly merits this alacrity:** לִהְיוֹת כָּל רְצוֹנוֹ תָּמִיד רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא וְאֵין לוֹ דָּבָר אַחֵר בָּעוֹלָם — **that his entire will should always be only to fulfill the Creator's will, with nothing else in his world.** וְזֶה מְקֹרֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ כִּי נֶפֶשׁ הוּא רָצוֹן — **This is called mesiras nefesh, for nefesh means will,** וְעַל יְדֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בְּפוֹעַל זוֹכִין לְזֶה הָרָצוֹן. — **and through actual mesiras nefesh one merits this will.**

Love independent of reward

אָכֵן תַּלְמִידֵי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם לִהְיוֹת עוֹבֵד הַשֵּׁם שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנַת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס רַק לִשְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ בִּלְבַד. — **The disciples of Avraham Avinu, however, seek to serve Hashem without the intention of receiving reward, solely for His blessed Name.** וּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ הוּא עֵדוּת עַל זֶה שֶׁהִיא שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנַת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס — **Mesiras nefesh testifies that this service is without the intention of receiving reward,** כִּי מִי שֶׁמּוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ וּמְאוֹדוֹ לַשָּׁמַיִם הֵיא אַהֲבָה שֶׁאֵינָהּ תְּלוּיָה בְּדָבָר — **for when someone surrenders his life and his resources to Heaven, this is a love independent of any condition,** וְלָכֵן אֵינָהּ בְּטֵילָה לְעוֹלָם.[34] — **and therefore it never ceases.**

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[32] **Bereishis 9:5**. “But your blood, of your lives, I shall demand; from every animal I shall demand it, and from the hand of man, from the hand of each man's brother, I shall demand the life of man.”

[33] **Agra DeKalla, Beshalach 7, within the discussion beginning Bamidrash parshas Vayeishev**.

[34] **Sfas Emes, Balak, 5656, second paragraph; Sefaria Numbers, Balak 21:2**.